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Kristen Steffler Varona

Senior Product Manager (PM/TPM) | Product & Engineering Leader | AI-Native SaaS

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

I lead product by holding the full picture in view while driving short-term progress that compounds toward long-term goals. I prioritize with a customer-first mindset, sequencing the work that delivers real value now without compromising where the product needs to go.

I have done this as a technical product leader, a founder, and a consultant across SaaS, enterprise platforms, and retail technology.

At Kanban Zone I took a product from zero to a patented, profitable SaaS platform. At Plexus I walked into a four-year stalled modernization initiative, diagnosed the real blockers, and delivered the full program in fourteen months. In consulting, I have helped enterprise organizations at American Express, Morgan Stanley, AZBCBS, and Best Western connect product direction to measurable business outcomes.

Deep retail technology background spanning point of sale, payments, taxes, pricing, and enterprise platform architecture across both vendor and operator environments.

CORE SKILLS

Product & Delivery	Product Roadmaps Stakeholder Management Customer Insights Backlog Management Agile/Sprint Planning Features, User Stories & Acceptance Criteria Release Management Product Discovery A/B Testing KPIs & Metrics Go-to-Market
Technical	APIs & System Integration Platform Architecture PaaS SQL Event-Driven Systems CI/CD Cloud Platforms AI/ML Product Integration Data Modeling
Tools	Jira Confluence PostHog FullStory GitHub Figma Claude OpenAI APIs
Domain	Retail Technology POS Systems E-Commerce Subscription, Payments & Reconciliation SaaS Platforms Enterprise Software Regulatory Compliance

EXPERIENCE

TrailOS

Founder & Head of Product

February 2026 – Present

Built and launched two AI-native consumer SaaS products as a solo founder, owning product strategy, engineering execution, and go-to-market from zero. WildLog and TripForge are live, integrated products using GPT-4 and Claude as core product intelligence layers.

- Built an AI-native consumer SaaS focused on outdoor activity capture and trip planning, combining journaling, recommendation systems, and personalized planning workflows into a unified product experience.
- Developed WildLog, an AI-powered activity journaling application that transforms raw trail notes into structured, shareable trip reports.
- Developed TripForge, an AI-assisted trip planning product that generates personalized adventure recommendations based on user preferences and behavioral patterns.
- Led end-to-end product strategy, UX design, engineering execution, and go-to-market definition across both products.
- Designed product architecture and iteration model to support rapid MVP development and long-term extensibility.

- Integrated AI capabilities across core workflows to enable personalized recommendations, content generation, and planning assistance.

Plexus Worldwide

Manager, (Technical Product Management)

May 2024 – July 2025

Rescued a four-year stalled enterprise modernization program, delivering it in 14 months while absorbing a concurrent Japan market expansion mid-stream. Led seven engineers across onshore, offshore, and contract arrangements while owning the full technical product roadmap and executive stakeholder alignment.

- Led a critical-path enterprise modernization initiative through full production readiness in 14 months, establishing strategy, scope, and execution structure across engineering and executive stakeholders.
- Built and operationalized the technical backlog from zero, translating business priorities into structured epics, sequencing, and execution plans across distributed onshore/offshore engineering teams.
- Directed cross-functional alignment across product, engineering, and executive leadership, resolving competing priorities and establishing clear delivery expectations without formal authority.
- Managed parallel initiatives mid-stream, including a Japan market expansion and lower-environment platform buildout, navigating cross-system dependencies across logistics, e-commerce, direct sales, and international market integrations while re-sequencing work to maintain delivery continuity across all workstreams.
- Owned the e-commerce technical roadmap across APIs, platform capabilities, and release management, aligning delivery execution with business KPIs and operational goals.
- Improved release cadence and delivery predictability by 50%, strengthening Agile execution practices and establishing more consistent production deployment cycles.
- Managed a team of seven engineers across onshore, offshore, and contract arrangements, including performance reviews, growth planning, and hiring and termination decisions.

Kanban Zone LLC

Co-Founder, CTO & Product Architect

Jan 2017 – Oct 2023

Co-founded and scaled a B2B SaaS workflow platform from zero to a patented, profitable product, owning every product, architecture, and engineering decision for seven years. Grew to 3,000+ users on a bootstrapped budget while maintaining a high-velocity daily deployment cadence.

- Designed and scaled a SaaS platform as a full-stack system, including system architecture, API design, and end-to-end technical product direction, serving as the de facto product and engineering leadership function.
- Led continuous product delivery over six years, operating a high-velocity release cadence while driving roadmap prioritization and cross-stream product evolution.
- Applied product telemetry (usage behavior, funnels, and retention metrics) to inform prioritization, identify friction points, and optimize activation and engagement outcomes.
- Led structured customer discovery and iterative beta programs, translating user feedback into product decisions that improved usability and market alignment.
- Directed build-vs-buy decisions, roadmap prioritization, and delivery tradeoffs across engineering execution, product quality, and timeline constraints.
- Built and led a cross-functional team of three to five distributed members spanning UX, development, and QA, independently sourcing, interviewing, and selecting team members.
- Designed and evolved subscription and add-on monetization systems, improving conversion flows through targeted in-product mechanisms and pricing iteration.

Office Depot Latin America

Contract, Retail Systems SME (POS & Regulatory Systems)

February 2019 – February 2023

Owned product delivery and technical maintenance for a multi-country POS platform across three retail chains in Latin America, each with distinct codebases and regulatory requirements. Ensured zero disruption to revenue-critical store operations while advising on next-generation POS integration and rollout strategy.

- Maintained and evolved a multi-country point-of-sale platform across Office Depot, RadioShack, and Marchant brands, operating distinct regional codebases with varying regulatory and operational constraints.
- Owned hardware integration and API strategy across distributed retail POS environments, ensuring consistent interoperability across device types and store configurations.
- Delivered enhancements, defect remediation, and regulatory compliance updates across multiple retail systems while supporting migration toward a next-generation POS platform, ensuring continuity of revenue-critical store operations.
- Advised on integration architecture and rollout strategy for next-generation POS systems, bridging legacy platform constraints with modernized retail and payment capabilities across regions.

Blue Drop Solutions LLC

Technical Product Consultant | Product & Engineering Delivery

May 2011 – March 2024

Delivered product and engineering transformation engagements for enterprise clients, including American Express, Best Western International, and Blue Cross Blue Shield of Arizona. Led a full-scale agile and DevOps transformation at Best Western, restructuring the technology organization from waterfall to continuous delivery.

- Provided executive advisory to senior leadership on product strategy, delivery prioritization, and organizational operating model design across enterprise technology environments.
- Delivered enterprise transformation engagements across fintech, healthcare, hospitality, and retail clients, including American Express, Blue Cross Blue Shield of Arizona, and CSAA.
- Led a full-scale technology and delivery transformation at Best Western International, restructuring teams into cross-functional delivery units and transitioning the organization from waterfall execution to continuous delivery practices.
- Introduced scaled Kanban, DevOps practices, and test automation approaches to improve delivery flow, predictability, and engineering throughput across distributed teams.

JDA Software (now Blue Yonder)

Software Engineer to Technical Lead / Architect

June 1998 – 2010

Spent over a decade building enterprise retail platforms including POS, replenishment, pricing, loyalty, and payment systems for major North American and Latin American retailers. Progressed from consulting engineer to technical lead and architect, including a solo performance optimization that reduced a nightly batch process from hours to minutes.

- Contributed to a large-scale enterprise retail replenishment and supply chain platform spanning multiple teams, coordinating inventory and demand across distributed retail networks.
- Delivered custom point-of-sale enhancements for major North American retailers, including pricing, tax, compliance, loyalty, and payment systems, working directly with clients through requirements definition, BRDs, and production rollout support.
- Identified and resolved a critical performance bottleneck in a nightly inventory and pricing process, redesigning a core execution path and reducing runtime from hours to minutes in a high-impact production environment.

- Progressed from consulting engineer to technical lead and architect, operating across multiple enterprise systems and technologies while supporting POS, replenishment, and logistics platforms in production environments.
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RECENT PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

- AI for Product Managers – Pendo
- AI Fluency: Framework and Foundations – Anthropic
- Generative AI Fundamentals – DataBricks